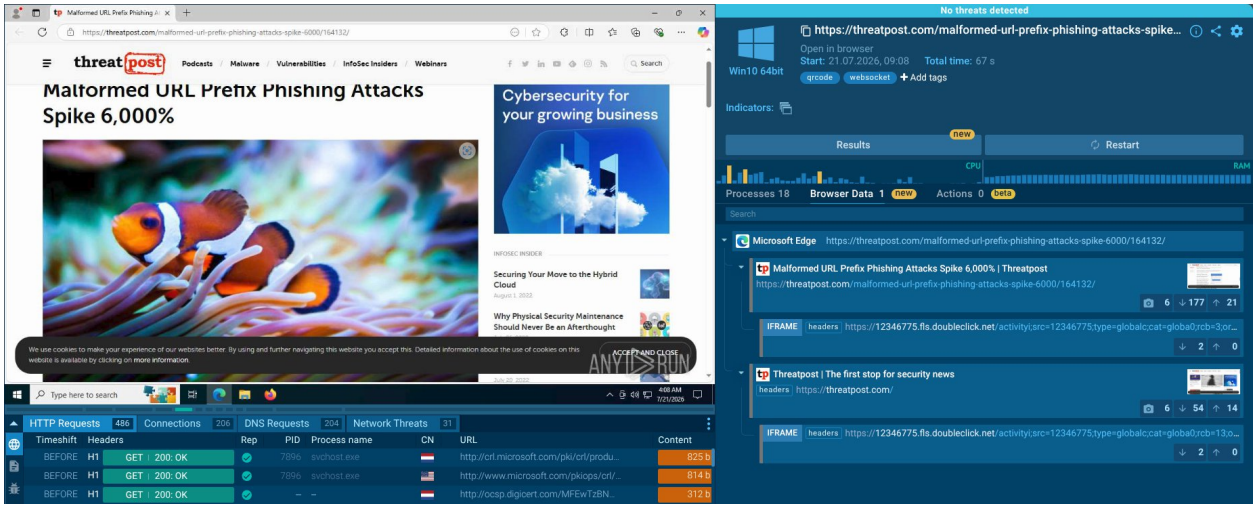
Event Information:

EventID :
66
Event Time :
Feb, 22, 2021, 08:36 PM
Rule :
SOC102 - Proxy - Suspicious URL Detected
Level :
Security Analyst
Source Address :
172.16.17.150
Source Hostname :
ChanProd
Destination Address :
35.173.160.135
Destination Hostname :
threatpost.com
Username :
Chan
Request URL :
https://threatpost.com/malformed-url-prefix-phishing-attacks-spike-6000/164132/
User Agent :
Mozilla - Windows
Device Action :
Allowed

Analysis Steps:

The URL which triggered the alert is associated with a legitimate website threatpost[.]com which deals with topics relating to Cybersecurity. It is likely that the subject of the article “malformed-url-prefix-phishing-attacks-spike” contained a keyword which triggered detection logic.

For additional verification the website was navigated to in a Sandbox and this offers additional verification of its benign nature.



Based on following Playbook procedure and the analysis of available information, this alert is determined to be a False Positive.

Report:

Incident Summary

Analysis confirms a False Positive alert triggered by an internal user accessing a legitimate cybersecurity news website. The proxy flagged the URL as suspicious, likely due to threat-related keywords within the article's permalink. Sandbox verification confirmed the destination is benign, and no further action is required for the endpoint.

Incident Details

- **Alert Name:** SOC102 - Proxy - Suspicious URL Detected
- **Target Host:** ChanProd (172[.]16.17.150)
- **User Account:** Chan
- **Destination IP:** 35[.]173.160.135
- **Destination Domain:** threatpost[.]com
- **Request URL:** hxxps://threatpost[.]com/malformed-url-prefix-phishing-attacks-spike-6000/164132/
- **Device Action:** Allowed

Analysis and Evidence

- **Network Activity:** Proxy logs show that on Feb 22, 2021, the user navigated to an article on threatpost[.]com.
- **Alert Trigger Logic:** The requested URL contained the string "malformed-url-prefix-phishing-attacks-spike". It is highly probable that the presence of the word "phishing" in the URL inadvertently triggered the proxy's detection logic for suspicious URLs.
- **Destination Validation:** threatpost[.]com is a well-known and legitimate website dedicated to reporting cybersecurity news and vulnerabilities.
- **Dynamic Analysis:** The URL was opened in a sandbox environment, which provided additional verification that the website and the specific article page are completely benign.

Actions Taken

1. Reviewed the proxy alert details and identified the requested URL as belonging to a legitimate news organisation.
2. Determined the alert was inadvertently triggered by security-related keywords in the article's title rather than actual malicious infrastructure.
3. Conducted dynamic sandbox testing to explicitly verify the benign nature of the page.
4. Declared the alert a False Positive and closed the ticket.

Let’s Defend Result

